

Chapter 09: Alcoholism

Brief Summary

This chapter presents alcoholism as one of the Grant Study's most important discoveries. Vaillant argues that alcoholism is frequently mistaken for a symptom of marital unhappiness, personality disorder, stress, or moral weakness, when the long prospective record shows it often causes those problems. The chapter is especially valuable because it follows drinking patterns over decades rather than relying on self-report at one point in time.

Key Study Findings

- Alcoholism behaves like a chronic disease over the life course, even though symptoms may fluctuate and periods of abstinence may occur.
- Short-term observation can make alcoholism look like a temporary habit or lifestyle choice. Long-term observation reveals progressive recurrence and accumulating damage.
- Alcoholism was more often the cause than the result of dependent, sociopathic, neurotic, or aggressive personality problems.
- Alcoholism was also more often the cause than the result of unhappy marriages. This finding connects directly with Chapter 6's discovery that 57 percent of divorces involved alcohol abuse by at least one spouse.
- Alcoholism shortened lifespan through many routes: liver disease, accidents, suicide, homicide, cancer, heart disease, immune effects, and associated smoking.
- Seventy-two percent of College social drinkers lived to eighty, compared with only 47 percent of alcohol abusers.
- Active alcoholics died faster than abstinent alcoholics, but even abstinent alcoholics died sooner than social drinkers, often because smoking continued after alcohol stopped.
- Recovery was most likely when men found a nonalcohol substitute, experienced compulsory supervision with consequences, formed new loving relationships, and joined inspirational programs.
- A paradox emerged: the most severe and the least severe alcoholics often had better long-term remission prospects than socially successful, minimally impaired, late-onset abusers, who had less external pressure to stop.

Interesting Stories And Examples

- James O'Neill shows alcoholism reversing apparent cause and effect. Before alcohol problems began, he was seen as ethical and promising. Later his failures were diagnosed as personality problems, but the prospective record shows drinking as the engine of decline.
- Francis Lowell, later recognized as Bill Loman, shows how the same man can be interpreted differently over time. From one angle he seemed to be choosing a bad lifestyle; from the longer medical angle he had a chronic relapsing disease.
- Bill Loman's privileged background, talent, military record, and professional promise make the story especially important: alcoholism can derail even a highly advantaged life.

Why It Matters

The chapter's study value is enormous. It warns against blaming stress, marriage, personality, or childhood too quickly when alcohol may be the hidden causal variable.